

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

I chipped away at my debt. Then, as I started to apply more critical thought to my ideas about money and shame, and to talk more about letting go of those feelings of guilt, I realized that to remain anonymous for much longer could be perceived as hypocrisy. So, eventually, I dropped my cover and started talking about debt with my own face, voice and name.

Of course, my honesty about my money struggles also provoked some less empathetic responses, particularly around the time my first book was published, when the accompanying press campaign meant that my story was no longer confined to its sympathetic, and often empathetic, Instagram bubble. I watched myself reduced to my failings with money time and time again, the narratives of each of these stories focussing on all of my worst moments, my most regretful decisions. To a five-figure number that I had been trying to convince myself didn't define me. A lot of the shame that I had been working to diminish resurfaced and swallowed me whole. I wanted nothing more than to close my Instagram account and sink back into anonymity – for at least as long as it took me to regrow the skin that felt like it had been removed from me the moment that I dared to admit to something that so many other people experience. I saw commenters question my intelligence, the state of my marriage, my morality even, and it really, really hurt. It reminded me why I'd struggled to get help, or even to help myself, for so long in the first place. The urge to self-flagellate was strong, and I succumbed more than once to those feelings.